

Checklist:

Product Strategy

1. Define the destination

- ☐ Identify your **Point A**: where the product/customer experience is today.
- ☐ Define your **Point B**: the end-state customer journey vision.
- ☐ State the desired customer outcome clearly.
- ☐ Confirm the vision is compelling, specific, and aligned with the company's larger mission.
- ☐ Make sure the strategy serves the customer journey, not just the current product.

2. Work backward from the vision

- ☐ Start with the end-state vision and work backward to today.
- ☐ Identify the major steps required to reach the vision.
- ☐ Map the dependencies between those steps.
- ☐ Ask: "What must be true before this next step can happen?"
- ☐ Identify possible dead ends before committing resources.
- ☐ Avoid moving forward just because something is easy to build.

3. Conduct a gap analysis

- ☐ Compare the ideal customer journey with the current customer journey.
- ☐ Identify gaps in product capabilities.
- ☐ Identify gaps in data, infrastructure, or technology.
- ☐ Identify gaps in user volume, awareness, distribution, or brand.
- ☐ Identify gaps in partnerships, operations, or funding.
- ☐ Prioritize the gaps that most block the customer from achieving the desired outcome.

4. Sequence the work

- ☐ Decide what must happen first, second, third, and later.
- ☐ Consider financial constraints and runway.

- ☐ Identify what proof investors, executives, or stakeholders will need.
- ☐ Prioritize work that both advances the vision and supports the business.
- ☐ Make sure the sequence accounts for technical, competitive, financial, and operational dependencies.
- ☐ Leave room to adjust the plan as new information appears.

5. Evaluate strategy factors

Financial situation and fundraising

- ☐ Can you fund the development required to reach the next milestone?
- ☐ Do you need traction before raising more capital?
- ☐ Are milestones designed to prove enough value before money runs out?

Competitive advantage

- ☐ Have you included the must-haves required to earn the right to play?
- ☐ Have you identified performance features that help you earn the right to win?
- ☐ Have you included delighters that drive loyalty and retention?
- ☐ Does the MVP include a thoughtful combination of must-haves, performance features, and delighters?

Market segments

- ☐ Should you start with one customer segment before expanding?
- ☐ Is there a specific geography, vertical, customer size, or use case that gives you a better foothold?
- ☐ Can learnings from the first segment help later segments?

Outcome delivery

- ☐ Can you deliver the larger customer outcome in phases?
- ☐ Are you starting with a single product before expanding into a platform?
- ☐ Does each phase build trust and increase value for the same customer?

Technology and data dependencies

- ☐ What technical or data assets are required for the future vision?
- ☐ Do you need to build foundational capabilities before launching future features?
- ☐ Are you investing early enough in assets that will become strategic later?

Strategic leverage

- ☐ Can relationships, partnerships, patents, brand, data, or thought leadership create an advantage?
- ☐ Are there non-product assets that should influence the product strategy?
- ☐ Are you using early traction to strengthen your position before competitors arrive?

6. Establish milestones

- ☐ Break the strategy into clear milestones.
- ☐ Define what each milestone proves.
- ☐ Assign business KPIs to each milestone.
- ☐ Assign customer KPIs to each milestone.
- ☐ Identify what work must be completed before moving to the next phase.
- ☐ Use milestones as natural points to reassess the strategy.

7. Review progress and adapt

- ☐ Track development accomplishments to date.
- ☐ Summarize results and learnings so far.
- ☐ Identify next steps in the original strategic plan.
- ☐ Document any adjustments you are making or considering.
- ☐ Change the strategy when evidence shows it is necessary.
- ☐ Avoid reacting too literally to every piece of customer feedback.
- ☐ Make sure customer feedback improves the vision rather than replacing it.

8. Final strategy check

- ☐ Does the plan clearly connect today's product to the long-term vision?
- ☐ Does the strategy explain why this sequence makes sense?
- ☐ Are customer outcomes and business outcomes both represented?
- ☐ Are the biggest risks, dependencies, and constraints visible?
- ☐ Are teams aligned around the same strategic plan?
- ☐ Is the plan flexible enough to evolve without losing direction?